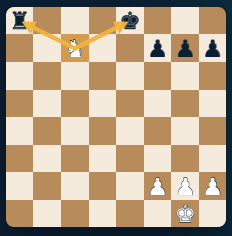
TURNING A CHESS ENGINE INTO SCIENCE AI

Chess AI is now solving science problems.

The search that lets a computer beat chess champions now helps scientists at **Brookhaven National Laboratory** decide which measurement to take next. In one week, students build a chess engine named **Remus** in Python, then turn its thinking on a science puzzle.

5 days, 8:30 to 4:30 | High school, 14 to 18 | Know how to code

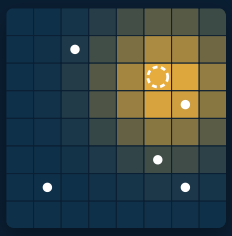


ON THE BOARD

Which move next?

Remus looks ahead and finds the knight fork.

SAME SEARCH: LOOK AHEAD, SCORE, CHOOSE



IN THE LAB

Which measurement next?

An AI picks the spot most likely to reveal the hidden peak.

Five days, four engines

EACH DAY ADDS A VERSION

DAY 1

Remus1 plays legal chess

Every rule of chess. By the afternoon Remus1 plays you in Lucas Chess, at random.

206 lines of code

DAY 2

Remus2 searches ahead

Scoring and alpha-beta search. Remus2 plays Stockfish set to 1500 Elo.

155 lines of code

DAY 3

Remus3 adds the biggest gains

An opening book, a memory of positions, and the clock. Remus3 plays Remus2.

193 lines of code

DAY 4

Remus4 adds everything else

Draws, pruning, and the endgame. Remus4 plays Remus3 and Stockfish.

177 lines of code

DAY 5

Solve a science problem

Find a hidden peak, name the crystals in an X-ray pattern, and share your results.

60 lines of code

Every day

FIVE WEEKDAYS IN A ROW

8:30 to 10:00	10:00	10:30 to 12:00	12:00 to 1:00	1:00 to 2:30	2:30	3:00 to 4:30
Period 1	Break	Period 2	Lunch	Period 3	Break	Period 4

How a period runs: a short talk on the next chess rule or engine idea, then students type the next part of Remus from the instructor's version and run it. One types, one reads aloud and checks, and you swap every period.

YOUR SCIENCE CHALLENGE ON DAY 5

Find the hidden peak.

Program an AI that tracks down a hidden hot spot in as few measurements as possible. Then aim your chess search at a real beamline question: which crystals are in a powder? Scientists at Brookhaven's NSLS-II ask it every day.

You take home your four engines and science programs on a USB drive, and you can install Lucas Chess free at home on Windows to keep playing against the Remus engine you have developed.

For parents

Does my child need a laptop?
No. Each student pair uses a class laptop with everything installed. Twenty students work with a teacher and an assistant.

Will my child need online accounts?
No. There are no sign-ups of any kind. All work stays on the class laptops and goes home on USB.

Does my child need to know how to code?
Yes, the basics: functions, loops, and lists, in any language such as Java. Your child also needs to know how the pieces move and read chess notation such as e4 and Nf3.

You are ready if you

- ✔ know the basics of coding
- ✔ know how each piece moves and read chess notation
- ✔ can stay focused while tracing algorithms
- ✔ want to learn how AI works